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Morphological Differences Between American and British English

Research Question

What are the main morphological differences between American English and British English, and what historical and linguistic factors help explain these variations?

1. Introduction

One of the most spoken languages worldwide is English, and due to its great expansion, different varieties have developed, influenced by geographical, historical, and social factors (Trudgill and Hannah 8). Among these standard national varieties, American English (AmE) and British English (BrE) represent the two most prominent and influential standards globally (Trudgill and Hannah 8). Although their linguistic origin is the same and they allow mutual intelligibility between speakers, systematic differences exist across various levels of the language, particularly within morphology (Toscu 2019; Trudgill and Hannah 8).

Morphology is the subfield of linguistics responsible for studying the internal structure and formation of words, as well as explaining how a language changes and restructures over time (Yule 67). Morphological variations can be observed in the way grammatical information is

expressed through different word forms, such as verb pairs (learned/learnt, burned/burnt) or past participle selections (got/gotten) (Oancea 2021).

When learning English or studying descriptive linguistics, students often confuse simple spelling differences (such as color versus colour) with true structural differences in grammar or word formation (Kortmann and Szmrecsanyi 1146). Therefore, the purpose of this research is to identify, compare, and explain the main structural and morphological characteristics that distinguish American English from British English, addressing both linguistic patterns and underlying historical factors.

2. Research Objectives

General Objective:

To analyze the main inflectional and derivational morphological differences between standard American English and British English through a qualitative and comparative approach.

Specific Objectives:

1. To define fundamental morphological concepts, including the classification of morphemes, inflection, and derivation.

2. To categorize representative examples of verb morphology, noun formation, and suffix variations in both standard varieties.

3. To explain the historical, cultural, and structural mechanisms—such as colonial lag and morphological regularization—that caused this dialectal divergence.

3. Theoretical Framework

To properly examine this topic, we rely on core concepts from general linguistics and foundational studies by experts who have thoroughly investigated how the English language varies around the world.

3.1 What is Morphology and How Are Words Structured?

Morphology is formally defined as the branch of linguistics responsible for studying the internal structure of words and the systematic rules governing how they are formed (Yule 67). Following the insights on George Yule's theoretical model compiled by Alam et al., human language operates as an organized system with precise building blocks, allowing linguists to scientifically analyze how meaning is structured across different regions (103).

The fundamental unit of morphological analysis is the morpheme, which is defined as the smallest indivisible unit of a language that carries its own meaning or fulfills a grammatical function (Yule 67). Morphemes are structurally divided into two main groups:

• Free Morphemes: These are autonomous words that can stand alone and possess full lexical meaning by themselves (for example, base verbs like learn, burn, or get) (Yule 67).

• Bound Morphemes: These are dependent elements that cannot appear in isolation and must obligatorily attach to a base word as affixes, such as prefixes or suffixes (for example, the endings -ed, -t, -en, or -wards) (Yule 67).

3.2 Words That Change Due to Grammar (Inflection) Versus New Words (Derivation)

Yule and Alam et al. explain that bound morphemes serve two completely different morphological operations (104):

1. Inflectional Morphology:

Function: Its sole purpose is to add grammatical information (such as past tense, aspect, person, or number) to a word without altering its core lexical meaning or its grammatical category (Yule 68).

Dialectal Application: This is clearly observed in past tense and past participle verb paradigms. While American English shows a strong preference for regular marking using the

suffix -ed (learned, burned), British English tends to retain older irregular historical variants ending in -t (learnt, burnt) (Kortmann and Szmrecsanyi 1146).

2. Derivational Morphology:

Function: This process involves adding derivational affixes to create entirely new lexemes or change the grammatical category of a base word (for example, turning a verb into an adjective or an adverb) (Yule 68).

Dialectal Application: This is noticeable in directional and adverbial suffixes. American English generally favors the base form without a plural suffix for directional adverbs (forward, toward), whereas British English systematically uses the derivational suffix -s (forwards, towards).

3.3 Historical and Structural Causes of Divergence

The differences in word formation between both varieties do not happen by chance; they are the result of well-documented historical and typological processes studied by prominent experts such as Günter Rohdenburg, Julia Schlüter, Bernd Kortmann, and Benedikt Szmrecsanyi:

• Colonial Lag and Retention: As explained by Rohdenburg and Schlüter (4), when early English speakers migrated and established settlements in North America during the 17th century, they carried with them the spoken English of that era. Over the years, communities in America preserved older linguistic forms that subsequently evolved, changed, or disappeared in England itself. The most iconic morphological example is the past participle gotten: while it was preserved intact in American English due to colonial retention, it was simplified to got in modern British English.

• Paradigm Regularization: As Kortmann and Szmrecsanyi point out in their extensive research on the varieties of English, American English exhibits a much stronger structural

tendency toward the leveling and regularizing of irregular paradigms (1142–1146). American English prefers applying the regular past-tense ending -ed consistently (learned, burned), whereas the United Kingdom holds onto traditional irregular forms ending in -t (learnt, burnt) (1146).

4. Methodology

4.1 Research Approach and Design

This study is carried out using a qualitative, descriptive, and comparative approach. This design allows for a detailed examination of word structures and morphosyntactic features in practice, enabling us to identify similarities, examine patterns, and understand how specific grammatical forms are used across both varieties without relying on complex quantitative formulas (Kortmann and Szmrecsanyi 1142). This investigation is strictly documentary, based on the academic analysis of existing linguistic literature without conducting surveys or field experiments.

4.2 Data Collection and Information Sources

To ensure that the investigation is rigorous and reliable, data was collected from peer-reviewed academic publications, comparative grammars, and linguistic studies retrieved from platforms such as Google Scholar, academic journals, and standard lexicographical sources (Alam et al. 103; Kortmann and Szmrecsanyi 1142):

1. Standard Lexicographical Sources: The Merriam-Webster Dictionary (for standard American English) and the Oxford English Dictionary (for British English).

2. Linguistic Literature: Peer-reviewed books and articles by recognized authors, including George Yule, Alam et al., Kortmann and Szmrecsanyi, Peter Trudgill, Jean Hannah, Günter Rohdenburg, Julia Schlüter, Toscu, Plazibat, and Oancea.

4.3 Data Selection Criteria and Analytical Scope

• Exclusion of Non-Morphological Variations: We explicitly exclude features that correspond purely to spelling conventions (such as color vs. colour), pronunciation, or general vocabulary differences, as these do not involve underlying morphological rules or affixation processes.

• Structural Classification: The collected data is organized into comparative categories based on structural features: inflectional variations (such as past tense verbal markers -ed vs. -t) and derivational patterns (such as directional suffix choices -ward vs. -wards) (Kortmann and Szmrecsanyi 1146).

4.4 Data Analysis Procedure

Following data collection, the selected examples are organized into comparative categories according to their morphological features. Each case is analyzed to identify its variety of origin (AmE or BrE), the specific morphological process involved, and its corresponding historical or structural explanation. Finally, the findings are interpreted to demonstrate how American and British English have developed distinct morphological patterns while sharing a common grammatical foundation.

5. Collection, Classification, and Analysis of Examples

To identify the morphological differences between American and British English, several representative examples were selected to illustrate variations in word structure and formation. These examples are divided into two main categories: inflectional morphology and derivational morphology.

5.1 Comparative Tables and Case Analysis

A. Inflectional Morphology: Variations in Past Verbs

One of the most noticeable differences between these two varieties can be found in the formation of the simple past and past participle of certain verbs. While American English tends to favor regular endings with -ed, British English more frequently uses forms ending in -t. However, both forms can be found in both varieties to varying degrees.

Base Verb	**American English**	**British English**
Learn	Learned	Learnt / Learned
Burn	Burned	Burnt / Burned
Dream	Dreamed	Dreamt / Dreamed
Spell	Spelled	Spelt / Spelled
Smell	Smelled	Smelt / Smelled

Sentence Examples:

• AmE: I learned English at school. | BrE: I learnt English at school.

• AmE: She burned the food. | BrE: She burnt the food.

• AmE: He dreamed about his future. | BrE: He dreamt about his future.

Analysis: These examples show how the same verb can take different endings to express past tense. The suffix -ed represents a regular formation, while the ending -t corresponds to an irregular variant. This difference demonstrates that both varieties maintain distinct morphological preferences, although neither form is strictly exclusive to one region (Levin 62).

B. Inflectional Morphology: The Past Participle of Get

The verb get presents another important inflectional difference, specifically in its past participle paradigm.

Verb Form	**American English**	**British English**

Base Form	Get	Get
Past Simple	Got	Got
Past Participle	Gotten	Got

Sentence Examples:

• AmE: The weather has gotten colder. | BrE: The weather has got colder.

Analysis: The core difference lies in the past participle. American English retains gotten, whereas British English prefers got. This represents an inflectional paradigm variation when building perfect tenses. Notably, gotten does not replace got in every context; for instance, both varieties use got to express possession (e.g., "I've got a new phone").

C. Inflectional Morphology: The Verb Fit

Variations also extend to verbs that resist overt affixation.

Form	**American English**	**British English**
Base Form	Fit	Fit
Past Simple	Fit	Fitted
Past Participle	Fit	Fitted

Sentence Examples:

• AmE: The dress fit her perfectly. | BrE: The dress fitted her perfectly.

Analysis: This example demonstrates that morphological differences are not restricted to -ed versus -t endings. They also appear in choices between an uninflected base form and an inflected form adding a suffix. American English tends to keep the form fit unvaried in the past tense, while British English prefers adding the regular suffix -fitted.

D. Derivational Morphology: Variations in -ward and -wards

In derivational morphology, differences emerge in the formation of directional adverbs and adjectives.

American English	**British English**
Toward	Towards
Forward	Forwards
Backward	Backwards
Upward	Upwards
Afterward	Afterwards

Sentence Examples:

• AmE: She walked toward the door. | BrE: She walked towards the door.

• AmE: He moved forward. | BrE: He moved forwards.

Analysis: Here, the variation depends on the presence or absence of the suffix -s. Although both forms are grammatically valid across registers, regional preferences consistently dictate their selection, showing that derivational choices also contribute to regional identity in standard English.

6. General Linguistic Analysis and Discussion

6.1 General Analysis

Comparing these examples highlights several underlying morphological patterns:

1. Regularization vs. Irregularity: American English demonstrates a consistent preference for regular verbal paradigms ending in -ed, whereas British English retains historic irregular variants in -t (learnt, burnt, dreamt).

2. Paradigmatic Retention: The past participle gotten in American English illustrates retention of early modern English paradigms, whereas British English simplified the participle to match the past simple form (got).

3. Derivational Preferences: Subtle differences in directional suffixes (-ward vs. -wards) show that minor affixation choices create identifiable regional standards.

6.2 Discussion

These comparative results confirm that American and British English share the exact same structural foundation while exhibiting distinct morphological preferences. These differences do not constitute grammatical errors; rather, both variants represent legitimate standard usages accepted within their respective geographic domains.

Furthermore, historical development cannot be reduced to a single trend such as American English becoming entirely regular or British English remaining strictly conservative. Instead, multiple processes—including colonial retention, paradigm leveling, and regional frequency of use—interact to shape modern morphological variation without impeding cross-dialectal communication.

7. Conclusions

Based on the empirical evidence gathered and analyzed in this study, the following conclusions are reached:

1. Clear morphological distinctions exist between American and British English, primarily localized within verbal inflection (past tense paradigms and past participles) and derivational suffix selection in directional adverbs.

2. In inflectional morphology, variations such as learned/learnt, burned/burnt, and got/gotten reflect alternative pathways for marking identical grammatical functions. In

derivational morphology, pairs like toward/towards show distinct regional choices in adverb formation.

3. These differences do not hinder mutual intelligibility or effective communication between speakers of both varieties, as the alternative forms remain widely recognized and understood internationally.

4. English operates as a dynamic, evolving language. Analyzing its morphological variation provides valuable insight into how regional standards maintain structural cohesion while developing distinct linguistic identities.

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